

Gamifying Democracy: Elyze and the Politics of Swipe-Based Participation

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Abstract

In a context of growing abstention and disengagement towards civic politics, Elyze, a French mobile app designed for the 2022 presidential elections, mobilises gamification to transform the act of candidate choice into a more accessible and *fun* experience. This dissertation examines how such design choices frame the kinds of engagement they open or limit. The study uses a critical walkthrough of the app, complemented with a thematic analysis and an interview with one of its co-creators, to analyse how Elyze's mechanics and design elements echo critiques of gamification as bound to dynamics of self-quantification, self-optimisation, and trivialisation of complex issues. Simultaneously, its success shows that this format resonates strongly with users and that similar initiatives are likely to emerge in the future. In this light, this dissertation proposes to understand Elyze within a metamodern framework, as oscillating between tool of neoliberal governmentality (Schrape, 2014) and the attempt to make political programmes more accessible.

Key words: Gamification; Political Participation; Metamodernism; Elyze App

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CHAP 1: INTRO

“Politics is not a game. It is an earnest business,” declared Winston Churchill. Yet a century later, the language of games has permeated the contemporary political landscape through the rise of *gamification*. Indeed, since the democratisation of digital technologies, politics has been fundamentally reshaped, altering how democratic life is understood and experienced (Chadwick, 2013). From social media platforms shaping public discourse or algorithmic tools influencing campaigning strategies, digital tools have become embedded in the ways citizens interact with political content. And amongst them, gamification has often been framed as a magical medicine pill. In the early 2010s, it was promoted as a cure for disengagement in nearly every domain: education, fitness, dating life, daily chores, and even civic responsibility. Jane McGonigal (2011), one of gamification’s most outspoken advocates, described games as tools to *“fix reality”* by transforming how people engage with the world around them. Her optimism was mirrored by the rapid boom of thousands of gamified apps marketed to “improve” one’s life, promising to make it not only more efficient, but also more *fun*. In this matter, gamification is defined in this research as *“the attempt to enhance systems, services, organizations, and activities by simulating experiences similar to those experienced when playing games in order to motivate and engage users”* (Koivisto & Hamari, 2019; Deterding, Dixon, Khaled, & Nacke, 2011; Hamari, Huotari, & Tolvanen, 2015; Huotari & Hamari, 2012; Liu et al., 2017; Santhanam et al., 2016; Vesa et al., 2017), or to put it more simply, to turn a *non-game* into a *game-like* experience (Deterding, 2011).

The civic system is not immune to this growing trend, on the contrary: many policymakers, startups, and researchers quickly took upon the subject, embracing it as a significant part of the Civic Tech movement (Ilyin, 2024). The timing appeared to be perfect: for several years, many democracies in the European Union have been affected by a crisis of civic political engagement. This problem is not limited to growing abstention or declining party membership, but part of a broader sense that institutional politics no longer resonate with the lived experiences of citizens. This feeling becomes particularly obvious amongst younger generations, who tend to feel increasingly disconnected from more traditional systems of participation, that can be perceived as ineffective and outdated (Norris, 2003). In response, a wide range of initiatives, such as civic tech platforms for e-voting or educational apps, have

tried rethinking participation through digital means. In this context, gamification can appear as a relevant solution to the challenge of reconnecting citizens with civic politics.

It is within this landscape that Elyze, a gamified “*Tinder for politics*” (Le Monde, 2022), launched during the 2022 French presidential campaign. Taking the “swipe” mechanic from Tinder, users are faced with hundreds of anonymised political propositions from the candidates’ programmes and are invited to swipe left or right for approval or disapproval, before being presented with the candidate whose program most closely matches their preferences. With more than 3 million downloads, the app was a success, undeniably contributing to the visibility of the campaign and reaching an audience that traditional political communication often struggles to engage. But with this success also came controversies, from concerns over data privacy, or criticism that its gamification risked trivialising electoral choice to a game of swipe.

This dissertation is therefore about taking Elyze as a case study to explore how the app can be understood both as a *symptom* and a *solution*. It simultaneously embodies gamification’s criticism, while also opening new possibilities for democratic engagement by trying to reconnect youth with electoral politics through a new language of apps, swipes, and algorithms. The app is analysed as a symptom of neoliberal logics, building on postmodernist theories, while also functioning as a potential enabler, with its success making political content accessible to younger audiences. In this light, metamodernism offers a potential new framework to understand this duality. The objective is to trace in what ways these two seemingly contradictory tendencies coexist within a single application, and what it means for the future of democratic political engagement in the digital age.

To pursue these aims, this paper will combine empirical and theoretical approaches. It will proceed with a critical walkthrough of the app (Light, Burgess & Duguay, 2018), complemented by contextual materials such as news articles about Elyze’s public reception and a short interview with one of the app’s co-creators François Mari. This makes it possible to examine Elyze both in terms of its mechanisms and design choices, and in relation to the broader digital political landscape of the 2022 French presidential campaign. To do this, the [next chapter](#) will first review the existing literature on the following subjects: political participation in the age of digital media, gamification, civic tech, and metamodernism. It will be followed by a [methodology](#) section presenting the paper’s framework and limitations. Then, [chapter 4](#) will consist of the critical walkthrough analysis, followed by a discussion part

in [chapter 5](#). The discussion will first explore Elyze's gamification features through postmodernist critics of power, before turning to a metamodern perspective that sees these contradictions as central to its meaning and elaborates recommendations for future similar applications. [Chapter 6](#) will then conclude the dissertation, synthesise the argument and open on further discussion.

CHAP 2: LITERATURE REVIEW

It is first necessary to understand the main theoretical debates surrounding digital technologies and politics in order to situate the analysis of Elyze. Therefore, this chapter reviews four key areas: theories of participation and politicisation, gamification's context and criticism, civic tech (and more particularly civic gamification), and the framework of metamodernism. Together, these topics provide a foundation for understanding how gamified applications like Elyze can shape political engagement.

2.1 Rethinking participation

Political participation, as defined by Axford et al. (2018), refers to *“any of the many ways in which people seek to influence the composition of policies or their government.”* It includes a large spectrum of activities, from voting to engaging in political debates with friends. Yet, it is often assumed that participation happens exclusively within formal structures: therefore, the perceived decline in voter turnout or party membership, especially among younger generations, is frequently interpreted as a “decline” of participation (Putnam, 2000) or a commonly heard “participation crisis”.

To better understand this so-called crisis, it is useful to look at how political science has traditionally understood participation: through the lenses of political interest and political efficacy. Political interest can be defined as *“citizens’ willingness to pay attention to politics at the expense of other endeavors”* (Almond & Verba, 1963; Lupia & Philpot, 2005). On the other hand, political efficacy refers to *“the extent to which individuals believe that their actions can influence the government”* (Campbell et al., 1954).

Scholars typically distinguish between internal political efficacy (IPE), a person's belief of their capacities to understand and engage with political issues, and external political efficacy (EPE), a person's belief that political institutions will respond to one's input (Balch, 1974; Levy, 2013). These variables are crucial to understand young people's civic engagement today: indeed, while many still have a high political interest (IPE), their trust in the institutions (EPE) tends to remain low (Beaumont, 2010). Despite no notable change in IPE between the last generations, the reason for the perceived crisis in participation according to Norris (2003) lies in the change of how younger generations express themselves. Indeed, he argues that what we are witnessing is much less of a *decline* than a *transformation* in how

political engagement is shown, shifting from more citizen-oriented repertoires to rather cause-oriented ones. In this sense, the emergence of digital technologies such as social media and platforms has not exactly “depoliticised” the youth, but rather enabled new repertoires of action, and those happen to often be undervalued by traditional democratic metrics (Jensen et al., 2013).

Chadwick (2013) describes this mix as a “hybrid media system”, where online and offline forms of participation blur into one another, and where activism can take on even more forms such as further identity politics, and more creative or symbolic forms of political expression. Though this transition is not without consequences: while new digital forms are often said to offer more accessible ways to engage, they can also be more performative. Jodi Dean’s (2005) concept of communicative capitalism explains how digital spaces become full of invitations to react, like, share, and “have your say” on everything, but rarely in actual concrete structures that transform in collective agency.

On the other hand of political participation lies the process through which political interest itself is formed. Instead of treating interest as something fixed, thinkers like Rancière (1995) suggest that the politicisation process happens through subjectivation: the moment someone becomes *visible* in the political space who wasn’t recognised before. In this sense, becoming political isn’t just about knowing or acting — it’s about starting to *feel* that something concerns you. Rosa’s (2019) idea of resonance takes up on this, describing how political attention often comes from a moment of connection with others. Participation is not something people either have or don’t, but something that *emerges slowly*, sometimes unexpectedly, depending on how people are addressed, and how they feel invited in society.

These new ways of engaging do not reject traditional models but stretch them: participation becomes not simply just an action, but a relation to others, to the world, and to oneself. And in a context where digital tools increasingly mediate these relations, the question becomes not just *whether* people participate, but *what kinds* of political selves they are allowed to become.

These transformations in participation highlight the importance of looking not only at *whether* young people act politically, but *how* they do it, especially through new digital means. It is precisely in this context that gamification has gained popularity: as a design strategy that promises to reframe serious topics, including political engagement, in a playful, simplified and accessible way.

2.2 Gamification

Gamification is most defined as “*the use of game elements in non-game contexts*” (Deterding et al., 2011). This notion builds on a longer tradition of thinking about the importance of *play* in human life, from Huizinga’s *Homo Ludens* (1949), where play is seen as a primary way through which culture, meaning, and social rules are formed. This rather simple definition has become foundational in game studies precisely because it leaves space for the large variety of forms gamification can take: from scoring systems in fitness apps, streaks in language learning tools or fixed work objectives to push efficiency. Gamification, in this view, does not necessarily involve fun, immersion, or the recreation of full games strictly speaking, but instead uses specific game elements such as points, levels, challenges, rewards, or leaderboards in order to drive user behaviour (Schrape, 2014, p.22).

Some researchers consider gamification not exactly as play, but more as a persuasive interface architecture grounded in behavioural design (Bogost, 2011). Instead of judging gamification solely based on its *effectiveness*, some authors argue that it should also include its *ethical* and *political* dimensions, such as what kinds of subjectivities it produces. Indeed, from a historical perspective, gamification reflects a longer genealogy of behaviourist control. Fuchs (2014) traces its origins to Taylorist labour management. In this view, gamification is not considered as a new magical technology of the 21st century, but as a continuation of managerial rationalities from the 20th century that rely on tracking, nudging, and regulating user conduct (Thaler & Sunstein, 2008). Indeed, gamification often operates under this logic, flirting with *libertarian paternalism* (Schrape, 2014, p.21): users are not strictly speaking coerced into doing something, but *subtly guided* (or “*nudged*”) toward desirable behaviours through reward loops (Ibid, p.35). Following this logic, games are to be understood as actions that are constantly embedded within apparatuses of control in which design itself becomes a *dispositif* of power (Foucault, 1980) that regulates behaviour (Galloway, 2006, p.87).

Yet this raises major concerns about user agency and consent. Deterding (2014) warns that such systems risk turning its ludic potential into an “*electronic whip*”, especially in the workplace where engaging with gamification becomes often non-voluntary and exploitive. He argues that traditional top-down gamification fails to understand the underlying mechanisms that drive motivation, and rely only on *extrinsic* motivations (rewards, points, etc.) which can completely diminish users’ *intrinsic* motivation, such as their sense of freedom while playing a game. Or more problematically, these systems rarely consider the long-term psychological consequences of gamification in the workplace, such as burnout or depression (Hon, 2022).

Fuchs (2014) goes further by labelling gamification as an *ideology*, a symptom of a broader neoliberal governmentality, in which work and play merge into the sole demand for capitalistic self-optimisation through the figure of the *entrepreneur of the self* (Foucault, 1980).

Moving further from critics, some scholars have attempted to imagine what more ethical or *empowering* gamification might look like. Deterding (2014, p.305-323) introduces his approach of a *eudaimonic design*, considering Aristotle's concept of *eudaimonia*: an all-pervasive excellent dimension of life. He argues that the purpose of gamification in itself needs to be rethought “*from what clients want to what users need*” (Ibid.). Such a shift would require designers themselves to prioritise users' long-term well-being over short-term behavioural change, moving from manipulation to meaningful engagement. In design terms, this implies to move away from a one-size-fits-all gamification (Hon, 2022) towards a more open-ended and user-centred system, even if it means appealing to a smaller audience, which would open the door to more speculative design practices (Dunne & Raby, 2013). Following these principles, for example, a fitness app designed with these principles in mind would not just reward users with points for hitting their goals, but also might encourage resting, or invite them to explore diverse forms of physical activity as well, and adapt feedback to individual intentions and contexts. Woodcock (2018) also notes that gamification isn't always accepted *passively*: in some contexts, like call centres, workers have found ways to *subvert* these systems, turning them into tools for resistance or mutual support: *counter-gamification* exists, one that can directly push back against the top-down, from-above managerial logic of gamification that Fuchs and other researchers criticize.

These debates show that gamification is not a neutral set of design tools, but a larger contested practice that can either reinforce systems of control (Fuchs, 2014; Deterding, 2011), or be rethought to create more meaningful, situated, and user-led experiences (Deterding, 2014; Hon, 2022; Dunne & Raby, 2013). This tension becomes even more important once applied to questions of citizenship, where gamification directly shapes how participation is imagined and enacted.

2.3 Civic tech

Building on the previous concerns about the decline of young people's civic engagement, the gamification of participation has emerged as an increasingly attractive response. Many

policies and researchers (Hamari & Hassan, 2019) have taken up this agenda, researching how gamified platforms can be used as means to increase citizen participation. Indeed, gamification can be seen as a way to address one of the weaknesses in democratic engagement: its lack of affective appeal (Rothert, n.d.). While democracy possesses the “*bitter ability to be boring, painful and utterly pointless*” (Ibid.), games (and gamification) can have the potential of offering a more accessible and familiar entry point into political life, as well as creating new spaces for engagement, particularly for individuals who feel alienated from traditional forms of participation (Mahnič, 2014).

This logic is not entirely new per-se. Long before the rise of gamified participation, Voting Advice (or Aid) Applications (VAAs) had already emerged as digital tools designed to help users understand the political landscape by matching their opinions with specific ideologies or party programmes (Garzia & Marschall, 2014). Tools like *The Political Compass* or *Politiscales* have become particularly popular among online users, especially younger and politicised audiences, for their immediate results and similarity with online quizzes popularized by viral content websites (van der Linden, 2019). Their prevalence, particularly in Europe, has risen in recent years, with millions of users engaging with different platforms during election periods as a step in their decision-making process (Ibid.; Garzia & Marschall, 2014) or just for fun.

These platforms also reflect a broader neoliberal shift toward individualisation (Fuchs, 2014). They offer no space for collective deliberation, are often performed in isolation centred on individual choice, and scores are evaluated through an abstracted score in which individuals are reduced into quantifiable fragments of behaviour (Deleuze, 1990). Indeed, this approach can reduce the notion of citizenship to *clicks*, where engagement becomes no longer about collective agency but maximising user input (Fuchs, 2014). Such tools exemplify what Morozov (2013) calls *solutionism*: the tendency to treat political problems as technical ones, that can be simply addressed through optimisation, feedback loops, and better interface design (p.8). Rather than cultivating political subjectivities, these tools often aim to make participation *easier* and more “*user-friendly*”. By transforming serious issues into games, gamification is at risk of trivialising its content while ignoring the deeper structural causes of the initial problem: the distrust in political institutions (EPE) (Fuchs, 2014; Mahnič, 2014; Hon, 2022).

This is why the distinction between “*involving*” and “*enabling*” (Hamari & Hassan, 2019) becomes crucial. Indeed, in their literature review on gamified e-participation, Hamari and Hassan find out that most projects with the goal to enhance participation remain focused on

short-term behavioural change, using gamification to increase participation metrics, instead of long-term empowerment. They argue that while gamified platforms can “*involve*” users through clear interfaces and reward mechanisms, they rarely “*enable*” them in the deeper sense, giving them neither the tools or time to develop and nurture a political subjectivity in order to engage meaningfully with democratic life. Moreover, they warn about the fact that these platforms can embed specific *normative* visions of citizenship, privileging certain behaviours over others (Ibid.).

As the literature suggests, while civic gamification can create new spaces for engagement, it often does so within narrow structures. Without critically thinking about the *kind* of political agency these tools are meant to support, a lot of initiatives actually risk reinforcing the very problems they claim to solve by prioritizing participation metrics over truly enabling citizens with the right tools to navigate democracy.

Therefore, civic gamification stands between solutionist potential and post-modern criticism: the app can both open space for renewed engagement, while simultaneously reinforcing control. To grasp this tension, a relevant framework is needed, one that offers a solution to hold these two sides together: which in this case, is metamodernism.

2.4 Metamodernism

From the ancient Greek word “*metaxis*” used by Plato to capture the sense of in-betweeness, metamodernism is a term rising in popularity used to describe the cultural mood of the early twenty-first century. It is often defined as an *oscillation* (Vermeulen & van den Akker, 2010) between modern and postmodern concepts. Rather than being one or the other, metamodernism both *includes* and *transcends* (Wilber, 1995) the previous phase of postmodernism, which itself transcended and included the previous phase of modernity (Cussen, 2022), in the same way a pendulum swings between innumerable poles (Vermeulen & van den Akker, 2010). In this sense, metamodernism can be seen as a “*tendency towards integration*” (Dumitrescu, 2007) that does not replace earlier modes but rather makes them co-exist at once, like “a browser with many tabs open” (Dempsey, 2024).

One of the many features of metamodernism is its advocacy for the need of return of grand narratives (Freinacht, 2017). Modernity promised progress, which optimism was then highly criticised by postmodernism (Lyotard, 1979). But according to Freinacht (2017), “the Metamodernist has her own unapologetically held grand narrative, synthesising her available

understanding but it is held lightly, as one recognises that it is always partly fictional — a photosynthesis” (p.372-373). While acknowledging postmodernists’ assessments of society, instead of being crippled by them, metamodernism still seeks for hopefulness (Storm, 2017): “*it’s the belief that there is something beautiful in the striving.*” (Cussen, 2022) Metamodernists researchers argue this mindset to be essential to face the complex crises faced today, that they call “*meta-crisis*” (Vermeulen & van den Akker, 2010), such as the climate crisis, media crisis, the increasing inequalities, etc. As they argue: “It is a complex worldview for an age of complexity” (Cussen, 2022). This mix of naïveté and society consciousness also brings a second metamodern characteristic: *ironic sincerity*. It is not irony as dismissal, but irony as a way to stay hopeful while being self-aware: as said by Freinacht (2017) “irony brings trust. And trust crowns a winner” (p.121).

Metamodernism is often expressed through these oxymorons, pairing characteristics typical of modern and postmodern thought, such as “*ironic sincerity*”, “*pragmatic idealism*”, or “*informed naivety*” (Vermeulen & van den Akker, 2010, p.5). These pairings, though seemingly unusual, clearly capture the metamodern ethos that embraces these tensions as a mode of navigating through the meta-crisis of contemporary life.

Therefore, metamodernism provides a relevant framework for analysing cultural and political practices today, and especially for understanding how digital technologies (and gamified applications) can embody this same oscillation between critique and hope.

2.5 Summary

In conclusion, the literature shows that political participation today cannot simply be reduced to quantitative measurements, such as electoral turnout and clicks, but must also include other ways of participating, such as less traditionally recognised and more cause-oriented means of engaging with politics (Norris, 2003). In this context, gamification has emerged as a strategy that promises to make “serious topics” more accessible and appealing, such as it could be for civic engagement (Deterding, 2011). However, it also risks trivialising politics, transforming it into a matter of metrics of efficiency and control (Fuchs, 2014). A government initiative that manages to maximise clicks or “completion rates” may potentially *involve* citizens but would therefore not *enable* them to interact outside of the governmental intended framework (Hamari & Hassan, 2020). In this sense, civic gamification initiatives embody this paradox: it can open new entry points into political life, while at the same time reinforcing solutionist

logics that frame democracy as a matter of self-optimisation and UX design. The success of Elyze shows that these platforms resonate to an extent with citizens, and that it should not simply be dismissed. Metamodernism then offers a framework to understand the co-existence of two contradictions through oscillation, in which it continuously transcends and includes modern and postmodern thoughts.

The literature on Civic Tech has very little material on recent VAAs (Voting Advice Applications), as most research studies older websites that are not used at large-scale, and mostly used by already politically interested users. Elyze on the other hand, encountered huge success over a few days, used by more than 3 million users and had a massive uptake on social media, with no equivalent at this scale ever seen before in France. According to François Mari, one of the app's co-creators:

“There will be a before, and an after Elyze.”

(Interview with François Mari, 2025)

The success of Elyze will probably bring more similar voting advice apps to be developed for future elections, as its influence is already seen by the emergence of many other apps for similar subjects such as Pol (2023), an app that puts citizens in relation to their local deputies, or Agora (2025), an app launched by the government to ask questions about the 2026 action plan, just to cite a few. In this context, these emerging applications are particularly relevant to study, with Elyze standing out as the main catalyst that has triggered the development of many others already released, or still to come.

Furthermore, much of the literature on political gamification has offered important insights by examining its instrumentalization by politicians or governments, often through postmodern lenses (Fuchs, 2014; Schrape, 2014). Other contributions have focused on developing ethical frameworks, trying to find a balance between what can be considered as “good” or “bad” forms of gamification (Deterding, 2011; Hon, 2020). In this case, my research considers previous criticism of gamification through postmodern lenses as *acknowledged* and builds on it to present a metamodern perspective as a new framework of understanding. It does not seek to solve the tensions between the critics and the potential ethical frameworks, but rather to understand it as an *oscillation*, as means to situate these apps in a broader context and reflect

on their potential development. Therefore, following everything discussed, this dissertation proposes the following research questions:

RQ1: In what ways do gamified political apps like Elyze shape how users understand and perform political participation?

RQ2: How can we make sense of their design as both symptomatic of neoliberal logics and a potential vector for alternative forms of political engagement?

CHAP 3: METHODOLOGY

This following section will define the methodological approach used for this study. First, part [3.1](#) will focus on research design, in which two different methods will be used in order to answer these questions: the walkthrough method, the main backbone of the essay, followed by a semi-structured interview. Following this, [3.2](#) will discuss the ethical considerations to be accounted for. Finally, [3.3](#) will explore the potential limitations to the study, theoretically and methodologically.

3.1 Research Design

3.1.1 Walkthrough

The walkthrough method was introduced by Light, Burgess & Duguay (2018). They define it as “*a way of engaging directly with an app’s interface to examine its technological mechanisms and embedded cultural references to understand how it guides users and shapes their experiences*” (Light, Burgess and Duguay, 2018, p.882). It allows to understand what kind of user experience it produces through making explicit symbolic elements embedded in design.

According to Light, Burgess & Duguay (2018), the walkthrough method consists of two phases: the environment of expected use, followed by the technical walkthrough. Firstly, to understand Elyze’s environment of expected use, I gathered information from the app’s social media accounts, media articles covering its launch and controversies in 2022, and public statements from the developers. These sources were used to identify the app’s goals and operating model, in order to determine the environment of expected use.

Secondly, in the technical walkthrough, the Elyze app was downloaded on iOS and explored step by step through the onboarding, swiping through proposals, reviewing the results interface and further features, and exiting the app. Screenshots and notes were taken throughout, to record both the app’s functional elements (e.g. swiping mechanism, buttons, etc.) and all the symbolic elements that might be embedded in design (e.g. emojis, colours, etc.) Additionally, to interact with the app and generate a leaderboard of results, randomised swipes were ensured through a strict method of swiping left, then right, indefinitely.

For the purposes of analysis, every important information for the dissertation contained through screenshots needed for analysis will be translated into English using DeepL by the researcher.

The walkthrough method is particularly relevant for this study because it considers apps not only as technical artefacts, but also as cultural systems embedded in wider social contexts. As Light, Burgess & Duguay (2018), argue, apps are “socio-cultural artefacts” (p.886), in which interfaces and mechanisms guide users while also embodying broader societal values. This perspective draws on both science and technology studies (STS) and cultural studies approaches such as the Actor-Network theory (ANT), for which technologies are considered as non-human actors that can be mediators rather than neutral tools (Ibid., Latour, 2005). In this sense, Elyze is approached as a socio-technical assemblage that, in a sense, shapes how political participation is imagined. The walkthrough is therefore particularly well-suited for this analysis, because it allows the researchers to both document the materiality of the app and its affordances while also recognising the broader meanings of why it exists, its purpose, and controversies. By combining the study of Elyze’s expected use and target group with a detailed analysis of its interface, this method makes it possible to understand the explicit intentions of the developers as well as the implicit assumptions about politics and visions of citizenships embedded in the app’s technical and cultural features.

3.1.2 Semi-Structured Interview

A semi-structured interview was conducted with one of the co-creators of Elyze as a secondary method, in order to complement the walkthrough analysis and situate the application within its context. Interviews provide access to evidence that other methods may not capture (Gerson & Damaske, 2020), which explains my choice to proceed with this method. Further information was needed than the ones publicly available, such as the intentions behind Elyze and details about the process.

The interviewee, being a public figure of the app, was known to me through mutual friends and contacted via social media and decided to participate voluntarily. Given that the researcher is in the United Kingdom and the participant in France, a face-to-face interview was not feasible. The interview was therefore conducted through a phone call on WhatsApp, recorded with the participant’s knowledge, and lasted a bit less than 30 minutes. The file was then transcribed for analysis using the website revoldiv.com, and translated from French to

English via DeepL. Concerning ethical consideration, the interviewee was given an information sheet beforehand, a consent form to sign, as well as oral consent at the beginning of the interview. Please see the Appendices A, B and C for more information. Throughout the conversation, a semi-structured format was followed, prepared around a set of 10 open-ended questions focusing on the context of the app's creation, intended objectives, development process, design choices, controversies and perceived impact. This format was chosen to keep a clear structure during the interview, while also leaving room for the participant to add clarifications they consider important. It also fits the constraints of the interview, which was short, done remotely, and with a public figure.

While the walkthrough serves to understand how the app presents itself to users, the interview adds an additional perspective by understanding the original intentions by the creators behind it. However, the walkthrough remains the *main* backbone of the essay, with the interview complementing it. Together, these two methods offer a more comprehensive understanding of Elyze.

3.2 Ethical Considerations

In this research, ethical approval was obtained from the Research Ethics Office of King's College London (Appendix A). Prior to the interview, the participant (who is the creator of the application studied) was fully informed about the aims, scope, and format of the research through a detailed information sheet (Appendix B). They were explicitly informed that the conversation would be recorded and that their identity would be disclosed in the final dissertation. After understanding these details, the participant provided verbal and a signed consent form (Appendix C). The entire process was carried out in strict accordance with minimal ethical risk guiding principles. Given the nature of this research, the interview data is not anonymised. However, data protection measures were still strictly followed, and the inclusion of identifiable data was *justified* on the basis of the participant's role as a public figure in the development of the app.

In addition, throughout the walkthrough process, strict ethical guidelines will be followed. No personal user data are available, and all observations will be limited to the publicly available features of the application. Screenshots taken during the walkthrough process will also be

used for documentation purposes only, and there is no risk of any sensitive identifying information being exposed.

3.3 Limitations

This study presents clear limits in multiple areas that are important to point out.

First, this dissertation focuses on a single application, Elyze, and therefore narrows down the scope of the analysis. The application was developed for a very specific moment in French political life, and therefore, both its affordances and limitations are temporally fixed: conclusions drawn here may not necessarily apply for potential future versions of the app for upcoming elections, or to other civic gamification projects in different national or temporal contexts.

Moreover, the application is only accessible on mobile through the App Store and Google Play, and only the latest version of the application is currently available (2.1.0) which is based on the parliamentary elections that followed rather than the political candidates for the presidential elections. While technically there is no country restriction (according to research on fnd.io), the language barrier excludes users as the app is only available in French.

The walkthrough method is interpretative and situated by nature. It reflects the researcher's own experience navigating the app, which is shaped by their background, personal values, familiarity with the interface, and understanding of French politics. In this sense, the walkthrough is not neutral nor universally generalisable but rather pays attention not to what is visible but what is implied or hidden in the interaction design.

The addition of a semi-structured interview with one of the app's co-creators helps to understand some context about the intentions behind Elyze's concept and design. However, this also has ethical implications, as the researcher is both interpreting the app critically and have been in direct contact with its creator, someone known through a mutual friend and approached on social media. This proximity could add unconscious bias in the analysis or push to describe the app more sympathetically; though this position is embraced by choosing a method that is not aiming for objectivity and using reflexivity instead. Also, it is important to note that the walkthrough remains the main methodology of this research, with the interviewing serving as a complement to understand the broader framework of its creation.

It is worth noting that semi-structured interviews in this sort are co-produced moments, and as the interviewee, the researcher is also taking an active part in creating it. For the interview and the walkthrough, their position as a young French student with a political sciences background, which is the exact target demographic, definitely influenced the research to some extent.

Analysing this dissertation under a specific angle is a deliberate solution taken by the researcher, focusing on design analysis and a meta modern interpretation. It is also important to note that most of the authors cited are white European men, and while most are pioneers of the theories approached, it could definitely benefit to have exterior non-Western perspectives on Metamodernism in the future. Moreover, in this research, there are no attempts to assess whether political gamified apps “work” in increasing voter participation, or to measure their long-term effects in voting behaviour or civic education, notably because of the recency of the phenomenon and the lack of available user data. Still, questions remain open, and these are important areas for further research, which exceeded the scope of this project.

CHAP 4: WALKTHROUGH ANALYSIS & FINDINGS

4.1 Before the Swipe

Elyze is an app designed to reduce voter abstention by making French citizens learn about the different presidential candidates' programs for the 2022 elections in a playful way. The app launched on January 2nd, 2022, and was created by two students, François Mari and Grégoire Cazcarra. It was created with the ambition to re-imagine civic education through more familiar ways, especially for younger generations that grew up in a digital world (Interview with François Mari, 2025). The proposals were written with the help of volunteers affiliated with a centrist political party from Belgium called "Les Engagés". The idea emerged in response to a growing crisis of civic disengagement in France, marked by record-high abstention rates with 73% of 18 to 24 years old abstaining from voting for the 2020 municipal elections (Le Monde, 2020). In this context, Elyze presents itself as a *neutral* civic tool to encourage the younger demographic to be more informed about the different presidential candidates and their programs. Drawing on Hamari & Hassan (2020) review on civic gamification, Elyze's goal is less about directly *involving* citizens in political decision-making, but more about aiming to *enable* citizens with the right tools to navigate political programs in an age of misinformation and civic disengagement.

4.1.1 Environment of expected use

Elyze is designed for a one-off, short use on a personal smartphone. The app has a single mechanic, the "swipe", that is quick to understand and easy to use. And once the leaderboard shows the results, the app can simply be uninstalled right after. It was made to be used mostly during the French presidential and legislative elections of 2022, and the candidates have not been updated since. This choice matches the creators' aim, adding gamification elements for a familiar entry point to the app rather than an addictive hook for daily return or spending money (Interview with François Mari, 2025). The primary audience is mostly first-time and occasional voters, mainly for young people ($\approx 18-25$) as the addition of gamified elements and mobile codes shows. This was also explicitly said by the creators through interviews:

"We built this tool to reconcile our generation with the presidential election."

(Interview with François Mari, 2025)

While the app's target audience was mostly focused on young first-time voters or abstentionists, François Mari reported intergenerational use, including families and friends trying it together or sharing their results on social media (Ibid.).

Usually, political games marketed as such tend to only bring already politically inclined players and reach a smaller audience, which can be a problem for the games targeting less politically inclined players (Woodcock, 2019). Elyze is an exception: it is explicitly political, yet widely used. It reached beyond the usual audience because it offers something simple to understand, fast to play, which concerns every voter, and launched during a highly mediated campaign on social media aimed for younger generations (e.g. Hugo Décrypte, Brut, Konbini).

4.1.2 Onboarding

Upon onboarding the app, four screens introduce the user to the base logic of the app, which are: the swiping mechanic, in which cards can be swiped left, right, up or down depending on the user's opinion with a proposal; based on the answers, a leaderboard that then shows their best "match"; and an explore page that summarises the different candidates' views with useful links to understand and register for the elections. The final page states that the app is strictly non-partisan and collects no personal data (Figure 1). The reason being that two controversies marked the app's launch. The first one got corrected a few hours after launch, where users realised that in case of a tie in the scores, the algorithm would always put Macron first. The second controversy raised more serious concerns: at launch, Elyze did collect user data for statistical purposes (age, gender, location), though it remained optional and anonymised. To follow GDPR rules and avoid a lawsuit, the developers then deleted all data and modified the app so that no user information would be kept, and the issue was closed.

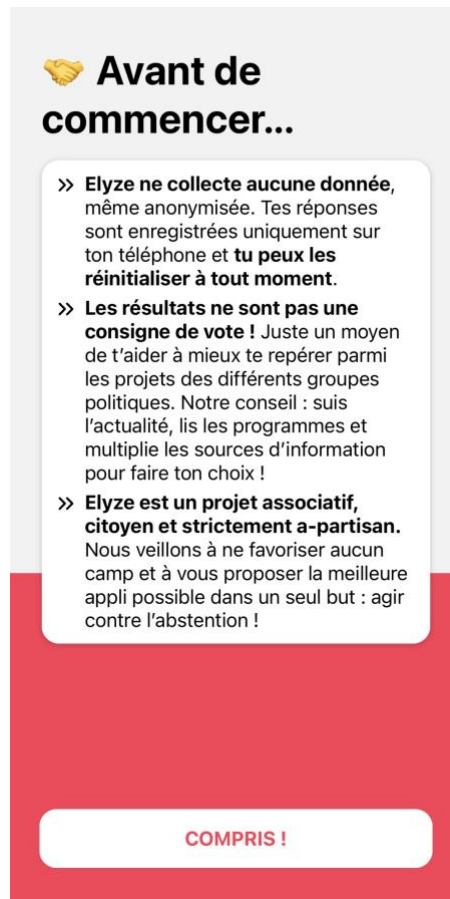


Figure 1: Fourth onboarding screen (translation of the bold text only: “Elyze does not collect any data, (...) you can reset them at any time.”; “The results are not voting instructions!”; “Elyze is a community-based, civic-minded, and strictly non-partisan project.”)

[Screenshot taken by the author, 10/07/2025]

When it comes to the visuals of the interface, the onboarding pages all feature large black text on a white background, guiding the user’s attention step by step, with an emoji accompanying each segment. This clean and minimalist visual approach strongly echoes Apple’s design, as acknowledged by François Mari. The white background with red shapes, or the application’s logo with the mix of blues and reds very obviously reminds of the colours of the French flag — blue, white and red — reinforcing the app’s civic identity. No need for users to spend much time on the first pages, as three swipes and a click on the “Compris!” (translated: “Understood!”) button leads the user directly to the main part of the app.

4.2 *Swipe right for Democracy*

4.2.1 Swiping

Following the short onboarding sequence, users are finally faced with the core mechanic of the app: the swipe (Figure 2). A stack of cards appears, each card featuring a candidate's political proposal. Their identity is not revealed to keep out any potential bias, though it can be guessable. From there, borrowing from dating apps like Tinder, the user is instructed to react to each statement by swiping: right if they agree, left if they disagree, up if they completely agree ("super-like"), and down if they are unsure. A quick button to learn more about each proposition is available, though the explanation is often quite short in order to keep the anonymity of the candidate behind it (Figure 2). There are no other links or sources preceding the swipe besides the few lines of text, no "back" function", no debate or interaction with others made available: input must be immediate, binary, and rational.

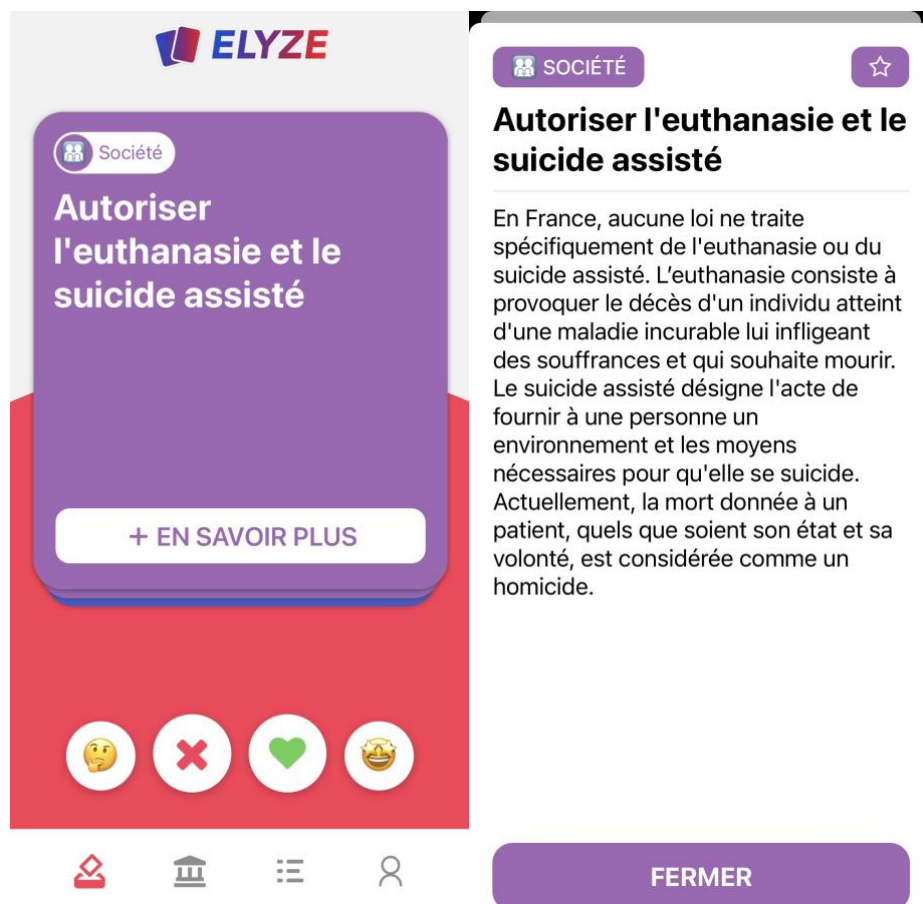


Figure 2: Example of a political proposition displayed in Elyze (translation of the proposal: “Legalise euthanasia and assisted suicide”), with the option “+ EN SAVOIR PLUS” (translated: “+TO LEARN MORE”)

On itself, the physical act of swiping is fast, intuitive, and only requires a flick of a thumb. This contrasts with traditional forms of political engagement that usually require time for discussion and reflection. While the verb “swipe” initially referred to something fast, temporary and easy, Tinder’s popularity has transformed its meaning in popular discourse to a binary approval/disapproval associated with the dating app (David & Cambre, 2016). Since familiar to users, implementing the same mechanism to Elyze allows users to intuitively use the application, playing on muscle memory of a left-right rhythm. But what is swiped here is not potential romantic partners: it is ideological content, values and visions of society. Dozens of political propositions to give an opinion on, and the repetition of the same left-right gesture faced with an abundance of information contributes to a sense of detachment (Virilio, 1986), the swipe thus becoming a thumb reflex rather than a deep reflection on each subject.

4.2.2 Proposals

The proposals and explanations are kept deliberately short, keeping in mind the target audience of young people. Some are more general (“Raise the minimum wage to a certain amount”), others more precise (“Launch the construction of a second aircraft carrier”), but all are mostly decontextualised due to the deliberate choice by the creators of making simpler, shorter and neutral statements, while keeping their provenance anonymous. This creates an effect of equality between proposals, as if they could all be weighed similarly, without their historical, scientific or economic stakes. One can easily swipe right all proposals allowing a bigger budget to each ministry or ignore IPCC reports by agreeing with proposals to stop investments in renewable energy without further scientific fact-checking. In that sense, the cards are not just simplified but flattened.

Furthermore, this framing effect becomes even more apparent when examining the brief contextual lines that accompany certain proposals: for instance, a proposal on lowering the retirement age is accompanied by a line stating “*Despite an aging French population, the political group (...)*” presented as a fact, though it implicitly shifts the tone that justifies the measure. These small facts can be argued to serve more at gauging the legitimacy (or illegitimacy) of proposals than to open them up to discussion. Due to the absence of possibility for discussion, there are no options for further reflection during the swiping mechanism.

4.2.3 Emojis

A notable feature of the interface is the use of emojis at different stages of the app. On the onboarding screen, they cater to younger users to familiarise them with the app. Each category also receives a dedicated emoji, such as a small plant for environment (🌱), a pile of books (📖) for culture, or a representation of two adults with two children for society (👨👩👦👧) (Figure 3). At first glance, they may seem like harmless visual cues; however, they each carries a deeper meaning. They carry a certain affective charge, implicitly pushing users towards a pre-framed tone for each category. The small plant emoji may nurture an aestheticized image of the environment policies, aiming to protect the flora and fauna, almost stripping it of the power struggles, dimensions and policy trade-offs it actually involves. Similarly, issues regarding immigration are categorised under the security, defence and justice category, illustrated by a police car emoji (🚓): this visual association implicitly considers immigration as a matter of law enforcement and control by police, rather than as a humanitarian or social issue. By relying on these seemingly innocent icons under the guise of familiarity with younger generations, the app subtly portrays a certain vision of society. The emojis act as pre-interpretative cues shaping the user's opinion before even reading the question.



Figure 3: Explore Page with a selection of policy categories [Screenshot taken by the author, 10/07/2025]

On the subject, the symbols associated with each potential answer are a red cross to disagree, a green heart to agree (both following the Tinder model), a thinking emoji (🤔) if unsure and a starstruck emoji (😍) to super-agree. The irony of the gamification model becomes obvious when pressing the starstruck emoji on a question about deporting immigrants out of the country: a violent exclusionary position, but framed through a symbol of joy and excitement.

4.3 Your match is Emmanuel Macron!

After a sufficient number of cards are swiped, the leaderboard finally appears with users' top candidates and their associated scores, under the name of "My Assembly" (Figure 4). Each proposal counts for one point for the party, while each disagreement takes one away, and a "super-liked" adds two. The larger the amount of cards swiped, the more accurate the leaderboard will represent the user's opinions.



Figure 4: Example of the “Mon Assemblée” (translated: “My Assembly”) leaderboard in Elyze (randomly generated by swiping alternatively left and right on each proposition)
[Screenshot taken by the author, 10/07/2025]

The leaderboard is presented in a vertical list format, with the highest matches occupying the top positions. The top three candidates are displayed on columns of different heights that resemble a podium, with the first-place candidate raised above the others in the centre. Just like competitive sports or video game rankings do, this visual hierarchy frames political alignment as a contest with winners and losers. Overall, it transforms the understanding of a complex political spectrum into an easily digestible (and shareable!) presentation of points and rankings. Indeed, the scores are then shareable on social media, with a generated picture of the user’s top 3 candidates resembling a podium with the number of proposals swiped. They can be sent to friends, added publicly to Instagram stories, or kept private. This transforms the experience of politicisation, being less a matter of social construction and resonance (Rosa, 2019) but rather turned into something “instagrammable”. In this sense, the leaderboard does not simply organise one’s preference for themselves, but can also segment users into different positions, categorising friends and family based on political belief

(Asmolov, 2018). Therefore, even though proposals are anonymised and results personal, users are encouraged to assume them by sharing it on social media.

However, in contrast to popular gamification apps, Elyze does not invite the user to come back every day, swipe indefinitely or subscribe to their monthly subscription. Here, the app is strictly non-profit, with no personal data collected, and a limited number of political proposals to swipe. It is an app designed to be used once, exclusively for the 2022 elections, and uninstalled right after. This temporality makes Elyze different from other gamified apps, built as a disposable tool. It is quick to onboard, quick to use, and quick to exit by pressing a single button or uninstalling the app: and once the app is deleted, no data remains.

CHAP 5: DISCUSSION

5.1 The Politics of Participation in Elyze

As unpacked in the walkthrough, the design of Elyze reveals multiple elements intrinsic to gamification. The fast swipe gesture, the ranking leaderboard, and the simplified and decontextualised proposals all operate like game mechanics. They script the user's actions on how to engage with political content, limiting the scope for interpretation. These mechanisms are not neutral: they mirror structural logics characteristic of contemporary digital capitalism. Therefore, it is necessary to understand how Elyze, and gamified civic participation initiatives more generally, resonate with neoliberal modes of governance, despite whatever the creators' intentions were.

In the following section, I argue that Elyze *is* political in architecture, *organises* the political through practice, and *produces* the political in continuation of a neoliberal governmentality.

5.1.1 Elyze (the artifact) is political

Even prior to opening the app, the claim of neutrality is fragile. Elyze cannot, by definition, be apolitical: as a socio-technological artifact, it is inevitably political (Winner, 1980). Technologies always carry with them certain values and biases, even if unintentional, as they are built within certain institutional, cultural, economic, political frameworks and the overall external logic of society (Ibid., p.130-134). Therefore, Elyze is not just to be understood as a technical tool, but a material arrangement that embeds broader social and political values. And what is technically possible shapes what is socially imaginable: as said by Lessig (1999), “code is law”. Here, political judgment is made through an architecture of code, in which everything counted as a valid political question or as a legitimate answer is pre-selected. And this preselection itself is mediated by the developers' understanding of politics, which, in turn, frame how users interpret their own positions: a double hermeneutic in which the act of interpreting politics has already been pre-interpreted for the user (Giddens, 1987). The app establishes what input is authorised, enforces further engagement for precise results, and produces corresponding outputs in the form of rankings that are presented as “your” political alignment. Despite the onboarding screens claiming neutrality, Elyze *cannot* be neutral: its architecture already governs participation at the micro-level, shaping what is visible and

imaginable as political (Lessig, 1999). This is a form of governance, not by law or debate, but by *code* (Ibid.). Therefore, the claim is clear: Elyze cannot, by essence, be a neutral civic tool, but is to be understood as a political artifact whose architecture already shapes the conditions of participation.

Moreover, beyond its architecture, the design of the app in itself is embedded with political assumptions. Whether it is through its colours (4.1.2), its use of emojis (4.2.3), or its display of a ranking board for results (4.3), all possess a certain affective interpretation. For example, the use of a police car emoji representing the “Security, Defence & Justice” category associates questions of law and order with an immediate, emotional cue. Another example being the small plant emoji representing the “Environment” category, inadvertently contributing to an overall aestheticized vision of environmental issues. This framing, again, even if unintentional, actively orients the user’s imagination on what categories means, like privileging policing over alternative interpretations such as restorative approaches, or shifting environmental policies to individual responsibility instead of governmental. This can be applied for all emojis, as they can all be interpreted within broader societal contexts. But the use of emojis in itself also redefines the affective register of politics: they soften political expression and make it playful, taking symbols traditionally used in informal contexts to lift the seriousness barrier associated with politics. Therefore, by importing this semiotics into a civic app, Elyze shifts political engagement into a register of the affect, subtly emotionalising politics through its use of a familiar interface and design (Illouz, 2007). This shift from seriousness towards familiarity and playfulness is intricate to gamification itself. But the use of gamification is not a neutral aesthetic choice but a structuring logic: it reconfigures the experience of participation by framing politics, a complex topic, into something to be consumed through light and affective interactions. Indeed, Elyze lowers the threshold of engagement: but it also narrows its depth in content. And this choice is, in itself, a political act of design.

5.1.2 Elyze (the interactions) organises participation

If Elyze’s architecture already organises participation by delimiting what can be seen as political, its mechanics extend this logic into the moment of use. The very act of swiping left and right to answer a complex political question already frames politics as a matter of binary choices, transforming participation in a quicker and simplified act. In practice, a question on climate policy is treated no differently than a dating profile: instead of thinking it thoroughly,

the user just has to register an instantaneous preference. The transformation of judgement into a quick gesture reflects a broader trend of *social acceleration* in modern societies (Rosa, 2015). Everything, including political participation, has to happen more quickly to optimize time to the point where political reflection itself is transformed: the time taken for deliberation gets reduced to the speed of a swipe. Politics are then reconsidered into something that can be consumed *in-passing*, similarly to browsing news feeds, liking posts or shopping online. This acceleration is not accidental but intrinsic to the app's design, which must compete for attention in a saturated media environment. In this sense, Elyze produces a version of politics that fits the rhythm of digital life: fast, affective, and surface level (Hon, 2022).

But this logic of simplification does not just stop at the gesture: it also extends to the way the app transforms these movements into quantifiable outcomes. Indeed, after a certain amount of swipes, once the leaderboard gets generated, the candidates are ranked by number of points according to the user's answers. However, what appears as an objective calculation is actually the result of pre-structured choice: the architecture of code (5.1.1), the framing of the proposals (4.2.2), the actors around the project (4.1), all influence the said neutrality of the app. Engagement is turned into data, points, leaderboards or rankings, all presented as an objective truth, in which individuals are no longer understood as coherent political actors but as *dividuals*, constantly fragmented into bundles of data (Deleuze, 1990). This quantification is not unique to Elyze but resonates with broader logics of digital capitalism, in which metrics become the primary means through which value and meaning are produced (Foucault, 1980). In this sense, the app does not just simplify politics into consumer-like choices: it reconstitutes the user as a statistical entity, a *dividual* whose political identity can be expressed through points and leaderboards. Therefore, what is presented as a tool for enabling citizens with the right information tools (Hamari & Hassan, 2020) participates actively in the construction of users' political identity. And once viewed through this lens, Elyze stops being merely a civic engagement app: it starts to resemble a miniature governance system (Schrape, 2014).

5.1.3 Elyze (the outcome) produces the political

As discussed in the two previous sections, Elyze cannot be reduced to a neutral civic tool. In its very architecture, it is already political, embedding assumptions that shape what can be seen as legitimate input (5.1.1). Through its mechanics, it organises participation into gestures and metrics, turning reflection and deliberation into swipes and points (5.1.2). Taken together,

these layers show that Elyze does more than mediating political engagement but actively participates in shaping and producing it.

The gamified elements are constitutive of how the political itself is made visible and actionable to its users. The framing of the questions, the mechanism of matching and claim of legitimacy all create an illusion where users *feel* like they are freely expressing themselves, even though their input has been pre-structured and guided at every stage (Fuchs, 2014). Instead of using coercion, citizens are subtly *nudged* into preferable behaviours (Thaler & Sunstein, 2008), in line with dynamics of neoliberal governmentality (Foucault, 1980). Within this paradigm, Elyze can be interpreted as its *symptom*: individuals are addressed as entrepreneurs of the self, encouraged to optimise their behaviours and identities according to market logics of competition and efficiency, and power is exerted through internalised self-regulation rather than direct coercion (Ibid.,). Civic engagement, accordingly, is reconfigured as a process where subjects are constituted as rational actors expected to perform citizenship through entrepreneurial logics of self-optimisation. And here, in Elyze, this takes the form of a political participation made through swipes and matches that simulate free choice despite being tightly structured by design, subtly shaping engagement through the lines of neoliberalism. Therefore, the side effect of the gamified design, further than a potential lack of depth, is a redefinition of what participation means: one that is pre-structured, accelerated, individualised, quantifiable, and aestheticised according to market logics (Fuchs, 2014; Schrape, 2014; Deterding, 2011)

This configuration has important consequences for how citizens imagine their place in a democracy. By reducing political deliberation into a matter of pre-selected binary preferences, this mechanism risks reinforcing the idea that politics is primarily about individual consumption choices rather than collective negotiation. And to follow the rhythm of digital culture, this choice has to be made quickly, and therefore the complex issues need to be easily summarised and most importantly: feel *fun*. What is lost is the very conditions under which political participation can appear as a space of conflict and shared responsibility, constitutive of democratic life. It conveys a very limited picture of politics, reduced to picking up a presidential candidate with the highest compatibility percentage. In this way, Elyze participates in a broader dynamic of civic tech apps trying to foster ideas of the “good citizen”, understood as a compliant participant whose behaviour aligns with pre-defined civic ideals (Hamari & Hassan, 2020). It leaves aside any other possibility of imagining politics, such as through collective actions, protests, cause-oriented participation, or negotiations of power in general. Therefore, Elyze exemplifies how gamification does not simply “add fun”

to complex subjects but does way more than that: it reorganises political participation, shifting its meaning towards market-driven dynamics. The outcome is a reconfiguration of citizenship itself, reframed through metrics. In this case, Elyze acts as a *dispositif* of power that channels behaviour according to neoliberal ideals (Foucault, 1980; Schrape, 2014).

Therefore, Elyze is not solely an entry-door to get into politics: it is, becomes, and produces the political. It *is*, as its architecture is inherently political (5.1.1). It *becomes*, as the swiping and ranking mechanisms makes it political in action (5.1.2). And it *produces*, as these interactions generate and normalise a specific vision of what politics can be (5.1.3).

5.2 Moving Forward

The reception given to Elyze, however, invites a shift in analytical perspective. Its massive success shows that this format of engagement resonates with people to an extent and responds to a genuine demand for new ways of interacting with political content. So, rather than stopping the analysis with the app's alignment with neoliberal rationalities, it becomes necessary to account for the contradictory dynamics that Elyze embodies. Indeed, as demonstrated in the previous part, the application actively acts as a tool to reinforce existing structures for the dominants. It takes part in the continuity of neoliberal logics as seen in section 5.1, despite being created in a hopeful effort of political facilitation by the two creators (Interview with François Mari, 2025). However, it is also definitely *trying* to democratise access to political content, often judged too inaccessible to younger generations, and it is working to an extent as its millions of downloads showed the necessity for new forms of engagement. Both of these frameworks co-exist, and it is not accidental: it shows a need for a new structural configuration that does not reduce Elyze either to an evil manipulation tool or simply naïve empowerment. In this light, and to answer the second research question on how to make sense of these two different dynamics, this dissertation proposes to apply the framework of metamodernism.

5.2.1 Metamodern Framework

Indeed, rather than considering this dual framework as contradictions to be corrected, it is possible to interpret it with metamodern lenses as an **oscillation** (Vermeulen & van den Akker, 2010). It is not to be understood as a balance or a grey area between an all-white or

all-black reality, but rather as a constant movement between multiple poles, in the same way a *pendulum* swings between innumerable poles (Ibid.), taking both elements from modernism and postmodernism. It takes from modernism its sense of hope and need for a return of grand narratives, and from postmodernism its awareness of power structures and distrust towards grand narratives (Lyotard, 1979). Elyze is not metamodern in the proper sense, nor did the creators probably intended it to be, but it nevertheless can be understood as embodying this duality within itself.

It is conscious of its limits, while still being hopeful and having the willingness to act. Further than being conceptual, this oscillation is being actively experienced *by the user*. Each interaction, each swipe, each binary answer, each result shown affirms the tension between the satisfaction of obtaining a clear and immediate answer and the implicit consciousness that this answer is not everything there is to politics. That Elyze is limited in design, playing the role of an entry door for understanding electoral programs (as stated in the onboarding screens) or as a fun online quiz to play rather than an all-encompassing mechanism to objectively decide the perfect candidate according to the user's ethics. Elyze does not act as a tool to change everything the user initially believed in, but rather pushes them to interact with the app, despite the awareness of its limitations.

To face the complexity of the world in the 21st century materialised through *meta-crisis* (e.g. political disengagement, distrust of politicians, etc.), Metamodernism argues for the need of a bigger vision again (Cussen, 2022). Recognising the structural limitations, while envisioning hope to overcome them, it moves away from postmodernist fatalism, a recurrent critic of the movement. This pragmatic idealism (Turner, 2015) also applies to the app's creators. Conscious of the limits (Interview with François Mari, 2025), they still decided to proceed with the creation of the app. They do not pretend to fix societal issues of political disengagement with the naivety of modernists, nor do they think of the app's limits as a brake. In a context of meta-crisis, these dispositions are crucial: they allow to engage in collective projects, without needing all conditions of certainty reunited (Storm, 2021). Elyze cannot be understood as simply transforming the complexity of reality into a simple and unique truth: it puts it in parentheses just for the time of an interaction, while maintaining, and pushing for, the possibility of a reopening. To quote Vermeulen & van den Akker in the matter:

“Their intention is not to fulfil it, but to attempt to fulfil it in spite of its unfulfillableness.”

(Vermeulen & van den Akker, 2010, p.9)

This means that the presence of features aligned with neoliberal logics should not automatically disqualify the app, nor should it imply that all similar projects that will be made are doomed to be disciplinary tools and nothing more. On the contrary, if a lot of new applications happen to appear for the next French presidential elections – which may happen, considering Elyze’ success – then the challenge is not to abandon the idea, but to pursue it *carefully*. The importance is to design them while being aware of its limitations, acknowledging that this will never be a magical solution to political disengagement like gamification evangelists argued for it to be. *But it’s worth a try*.

5.2.2 Recommendations

On this matter, recommendations for future civic app creators should begin with the recognition that such tools will always be developed and received within certain socio-economical contexts and will inevitably embed certain political assumptions. Therefore, the task is not to deny these constraints, but to design with constant awareness of them. Creating an app that relies on gamified elements and simplifies complex issues will necessarily fall, to an extent, under existing criticism. Potential frameworks can be explored to create more ethical forms of gamification to avoid pitfalls: one that is slower, reflective, participatory, plural and open-ended (Hon, 2022; Deterding, 2014; Dunne & Raby, 2013; Woodcock, 2018). But at the same time, it is important to acknowledge that many of the frameworks imagined for more ethical gamification do not necessarily align with the dynamics that make digital applications popular in practice (speed, immediacy, simplicity, playful interaction, etc.). Yet, if such dynamics are one of the few effective ways of reaching younger generations, they should not be discarded. Instead, the challenge is to work with them carefully, as seen previously.

One way of doing so would be to change the kind of *content* made available. Instead of centring on normative “duties” associated with the figure of the “good citizen” (Hamari & Hassan, 2020), civic apps could offer tools to inform on how governmental processes actually work and what *role* they can have in it: how to sign or launch petitions, submit feedback in public consultations, contact their representatives, participate in local assemblies, etc. This would enable citizens to see themselves not solely as passive recipients of information but

equal actors in these processes (Ibid.,), aiming to move beyond improving their internal political efficacy (IPE) (Levy, 2013).

Another way would be to rethink *how* gamification itself is deployed. The fast and playful mechanics that make these apps appealing can be redirected into further forms of engagement. For example, they can be used as a game for users to spot misinformation, expose how different news sources frame the same subject, or reveal potential contradictions between campaign promises and past decisions. There are many opportunities to keep the same gamified features but turning their outcome into a moment of learning rather than in an end to themselves. In this light, a game informing users about the candidates' programmes could still play a role, but its value would lie less in the ranking results than in encouraging curiosity and opening news spaces for reflection.

CHAP 6: CONCLUSION

This dissertation aimed to examine how gamified civic applications shape political participation, using Elyze as a central case study. The goal was to understand how its design and mechanisms structure the ways in which politics is made visible and comprehended, and to situate it within frameworks of understanding to apprehend the rise of similar apps in the future. Therefore, this research was framed around two main questions:

RQ1) *In what ways do gamified political apps like Elyze shape how users understand and perform political participation?* ;

RQ2) *How can we make sense of their design as both symptomatic of neoliberal logics and a potential vector for alternative forms of political engagement?*

The walkthrough analysis helped answer the first question, demonstrating how Elyze's seemingly neutral mechanisms, proposals and elements in design actually embed certain values and ideas of what citizenship should look like. Whatever the intentions behind the app were, Elyze cannot be understood as a neutral civic tool like originally claimed. From the moment users open the app, their political judgment is structured by code, which sets the boundaries of what counts as a political question and a valid response (Winner, 1980). This is extended through the users' interactions in themselves, in which the act of swiping left or right and the instant results participate in reducing complex subjects into instantaneous gestures, accelerating deliberation into the speed of a tap. Politics becomes consumable in the same way one browses a feed or shops online (Fuchs, 2014). The outcome of these elements is then rendered quantifiable, presented as objective results, though it is in fact the product of pre-structured choices existing within broader socio-cultural contexts. Therefore, Elyze does more than mediating engagement: it actively participates in producing it. Users are addressed as entrepreneurs of the self (Foucault, 1980; Deleuze, 1990), encouraged to optimise their choices and identities according to market logics. What appears as a playful act of political discovery thus resonates with broader dynamics of neoliberal governmentality, where power is exercised through *nudges* and internalised self-regulation (Schrape, 2014). This dissertation's contribution therefore lies in applying this framework to Elyze, to challenge narratives of neutrality that accompany civic tech apps and showing how they can be more than a helpful voting tool by reshaping what participation itself is understood as.

Simultaneously, the app's success shows that these same gamified and simplified mechanisms to grasp complex subjects succeed in attracting, and that something can still be done to enhance electoral political accessibility through them. The fact that Elyze reached millions of downloads demonstrates both the demand for alternative formats of political information and the capacity of its game-like design to capture attention. To simply dismiss the app as trivialising politics would therefore miss a crucial point, and even further when expecting similar voting aid apps to proliferate in future elections (Interview with François Mari, 2025). To try understanding a new way of situating these initiatives and answer the second research question, this dissertation framed this oscillation through metamodern lenses to help capture this coexistence of critique and hope, showing that these apps are not reducible to one of them but incarnate both and neither at the same time through constant movement. Therefore, Elyze cannot be solely judged on its instrumental efficacy to inform potential future voters or its alignment with neoliberal logics, but as a **micro-laboratory that experiments a new way of doing politics in an age of complexity**. One that is *flawed*, but also very *sincere*. Elyze does not solve political disengagement, but it shows what can be attempted, and what remains to be done.

Looking forward, further research could take a quantitative turn to evaluate if apps like Elyze actually translate into measurable political effects. Do users become more likely to vote? Or, like critics of gamification, do their effects stop lasting over time? Longitudinal surveys, for example, could clarify whether popularity corresponds to genuine impact or remains limited to visibility. It would differentiate between short-terms effects, like stimulating interest during a specific election campaign, and longer-term consequences, such as if these interactions actually push for sustained civic political engagement. Beyond questions of efficacy, further research could also examine how political participation itself is being reshaped by younger generations who have grown up with digital culture, where speed and immediacy set the rhythm of daily life. It remains uncertain whether this shift would reflect an actual transformation of the forms of democracy themselves, or if it simply is the emergence of complementary ways of participating alongside traditional ones. How these opposite tempos interact in political participation, or any other activity needing time for debate and reflection, could be an interesting subject for further research.

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Appendices

A) Ethical Clearance Letter

Research Ethics Office

3rd Floor
5-11 Lavington Street
London SE1 0NZ
rec@kcl.ac.uk



13/06/2025

Dear [REDACTED]

MA Dissertation: On political games and encouraging participation

Thank you for submitting your Minimal Risk Self-Registration Form. This letter acknowledges confirmation of your registration; your registration confirmation reference number is MRSU-24/25-49756

Ethical Clearance

Ethical clearance is granted for a period of **one year** from today's date and you may now commence data collection. However, it is important that you have read through the information provided below before commencing data collection:

As the Minimal Risk Registration Process is based on self-registration, your form has not been reviewed by the College Research Ethics Committee. It is therefore your responsibility to ensure that your project adheres to the [Minimal Risk Guiding Principles](#) and the agreed protocol does not fall outside of the criteria for Minimal Risk Registration.

Record Keeping:

Please be sure to keep a record of your registration number and include it in any materials associated with this research. It is the responsibility of the researcher to ensure that any other permissions or approvals (i.e. R&D, gatekeepers, etc.) relevant to their research are in place, prior to conducting the research.

In addition, you are expected to keep records of your process of informed consent and the dates and relevant details of research covered by this application. For example, depending on the type of research that you are doing, you might keep:

- A record record of all data collected and all mechanisms of disseminated results.
- Documentation of your informed consent process. This may include written information sheets or in cases where it is not appropriate to provide written information, the verbal script, or introductory material provided at the start of an online survey.
Please note: For projects involving the use of an Information Sheet and Consent Form for recruitment purposes, please ensure that you use the KCL GDPR compliant [Information Sheet & Consent Form Templates](#)
- Where appropriate, records of consent, e.g. copies of signed consent forms or emails where participants agree to be interviewed.

Audit:

You may be selected for an audit, to see how researchers are implementing this process. If audited, you and your Supervisor will be asked to attend a short meeting where you will be expected to explain how your research meets the eligibility criteria of the minimal risk process and how the project abides by the general principles of ethical research. In particular, you will be expected to provide a general summary of your review of the possible risks involved in your research, as well as to provide basic research records (as above in Record Keeping) and to describe the process by which participants agreed to participate in your research.

Remember that if you at any point have any questions about the ethical conduct of your research, or believe you may have gained the incorrect level of ethical clearance, please contact your supervisor or the Research Ethics Office.

Data Protection Registration

If you indicated in your minimal risk registration form that personal data would be processed as part of this research project, this letter also confirms that you have also met your requirements for registering this processing activity with King's College London in accordance with the UK General Data Protection Regulation (UK GDPR). Please note that any changes to the storage, management, or type of personal data being collected should also be included in a modification request. More information about how the UK GDPR affects researchers can be found [here](#).

We wish you every success with your project moving forward.

With best wishes,

The Research Ethics Office
On behalf of the College Research Ethics Committee

B) Information Sheet

Version Number 16/07/25

INFORMATION SHEET FOR PARTICIPANTS

Ethical Clearance Reference Number: **MRSU-24/25-49756**



YOU WILL BE GIVEN A COPY OF THIS INFORMATION SHEET

Title of project

From Play to Participation: How Gamification Shapes Political Engagement

Invitation Paragraph

I would like to invite you to participate in this research project which forms part of my MA Dissertation research. Before you decide whether you want to take part, it is important for you to understand why the research is being done and what your participation will involve. Please take time to read the following information carefully and discuss it with others if you wish. Ask me if there is anything that is not clear or if you would like more information.

What is the purpose of the project?

The purpose of the project is to explore how gamified political applications (like *Elyze*) shape young people's understanding of political participation. It aims to critically assess how such tools frame civic engagement and what vision of citizenship they promote in a context of declining institutional trust.

Why have I been invited to take part?

You are being invited to participate in this project because as the creator, you played a significant part on the creation and development of the *Elyze* App.

What will happen if I take part?

If you choose to take part in the project you will be asked to take part in short semi-structured interview (approximately 30 minutes) where we will discuss the creation of *Elyze*, its aims, design choices, and how you see its role in shaping political engagement. The questions will focus on the intentions behind the app, its reception, and how you view its impact. For example, you might be asked: "*What motivated you to create Elyze?*", or "*Why did you decide to use gamification in Elyze, and what did you hope it would bring to the experience?*" Participation will take place over the phone, for a short period of time from 30 minutes to an hour. As part of participation you will be asked to provide information about the development of the app and the intent behind its creation. If agreed with the participant, the session will be recorded.

Do I have to take part?

Participation is completely voluntary. You should only take part if you want to and choosing not to take part will not disadvantage you in any way. Once you have read the information sheet, please contact us if you have any questions that will help you make a decision about

taking part. If you decide to take part, we will ask you to sign a consent form and will give you a copy of this to keep.

What are the possible risks of taking part?

There are no significant risks anticipated from taking part in this study. The interview will focus on your professional experience with the development of *Elyze*, and you are free to skip any question or stop the interview at any time without providing a reason.

What are the possible benefits of taking part?

There are no direct personal benefits to taking part in this study.

Data handling and confidentiality

Kings College London is the Sponsor of this research and is responsible for looking after your information.

We will need to use information from you for this research project. The research team and authorised administrative staff will use this information to do the research or to check your records to make sure that the research is being done properly.

Your data will be processed in compliance with UK data protection laws, including the UK GDPR and the Data Protection Act 2018. The interviewee will be identifiable if they consent to it. We will collect your name and your position in the development of the app as the creator. The interview records and transcripts will be kept and stored securely on the interviewer's laptop only. All data will be retained until one month after the completion of this study. While your personal data will not be shared on its own, the dissertation, which may include your identifiable contributions, could be shared for academic or professional purposes, such as job or PhD applications, or academic presentations.

Further information on how King's processes research data can be found at:

<https://www.kcl.ac.uk/research/support/research-ethics/kings-college-london-statement-on-use-of-personal-data-in-research>

Please contact the research team if you require further information on data processing or a printed version of the webpage link above.

What if I change my mind about taking part?

You are free to withdraw at any point of the project, without having to give a reason. Withdrawing from the project will not affect you in any way. You are able to withdraw your data from the project up until 01/08/2025, after which withdrawal of your data will no longer be possible due to it integrated into the final dissertation draft.

If you choose to withdraw from the project we will not retain the information you have provided.

What will happen to the results of the project?

King's College London – Research Ethics Office - GDPR Information Sheet Template
April 2025

The results of the project will be summarised in my MA Dissertation for the degree MA in Digital Culture & Society at the Digital Humanities Department of King's College London. They can potentially be accessible to the academic and student body of the department. A copy of the published research can be obtained if you wish to have one, I can send it through email if requested.

Who should I contact for further information?

If you have any questions or require more information about this project, please contact me using the following contact details:



What if I have further questions, or if something goes wrong?

If this project has harmed you in any way, or if you wish to make a complaint about the conduct of the project you can contact King's College London using the details below for further advice and information:

Jamie Woodcock
jamie.woodcock@kcl.ac.uk

Thank you for reading this information sheet and for considering taking part in this research.

C) Consent Form

CONSENT FORM FOR PARTICIPANTS IN RESEARCH PROJECTS



Please complete this form after you have read the Information Sheet and/or listened to an explanation about the research.

Title of project: From Play to Participation: How Gamification Shapes Political Engagement	
Ethical review reference number: MRSU-24/25-49756	Version number: 16/07/25
	Tick or initial
1. I confirm that I have read and understood the information sheet dated MRSU-24/25-49756 – 16/07/25 for the above project and that I meet the eligibility criteria. I confirm I have had the opportunity to consider the information provided and to ask questions which have been answered to my satisfaction.	✓
2. I consent voluntarily to be a participant in this project and understand that I can refuse to take part and can withdraw from the project at any time, without having to give a reason, up until the 01/08/25.	✓
3. I understand my personal information will be processed for the purposes explained to me in the Information Sheet. I understand that such information will be handled under the terms of UK data protection law, including the UK GDPR and the Data Protection Act 2018.	✓
4. I understand that my information may be subject to review by responsible individuals from the College for monitoring and audit purposes.	✓
5. I agree to be identified in any research outputs, as explained in the Information Sheet.	✓
6. I consent to my identifiable data being shared with third parties outside the UK, specifically, for academic or professional purposes as outlined in the participant information sheet (e.g. sharing excerpts in job applications, conference presentations, or with academic collaborators).	✓
7. I agree that the research team can archive my identifiable data for future research projects. I understand that any use of identifiable data for future research projects would be reviewed and approved by an appropriate research ethics committee before my data were accessed.	✓
8. I agree that the researcher may retain my contact details to receive a copy of the final research report.	✓

Name of Participant

Date

Signature

Name of Researcher

Date

Signature

AI Declaration

I declare that parts of this submission has contributions from AI software and that it aligns with acceptable use as specified as part of the assignment brief/ guidance and is consistent with good academic practice. The content can still be considered as my own words. I understand that as long as my use falls within the scope of appropriate use as defined in the assessment brief/guidance then this declaration will not have any direct impact on the grades awarded. I acknowledge use of software to :

(i) Generate ideas or structure suggestions, for assistance with understanding core concepts, or other substantial foundational and preparatory activity.

[<https://chatgpt.com/>]